The paper kit

Scrapbooking and making newspapers

1. Your materials at a glance

Gather first, then make.

You don't need to buy much. Most of it is already in your house or free for the asking. Start with paper and a glue stick.

Do	*Don't*
Scrap bag	Buying everything
Glue stick	Perfect cuts
Heavy book	Waiting for the right day

- ◯ **Paper.** Newsprint pad or unprinted packing paper, brown paper bags, cardboard, envelopes, tags, old receipts, and a few pages from a thrift-store book or sheet music.
- ◯ **Real newspapers and magazines.** Ask neighbours, family, laundromats and cafés for what they're about to bin. Thrift stores sell old magazines for pennies, and Buy Nothing groups sometimes have free bundles.
- ◯ **Tools.** Scissors, a glue stick, PVA (white) glue for beads and leaves, tape, a smooth pen, a heavy book for pressing, and baking paper so wet pages don't stick.
- ◯ **For ageing paper.** Strong black tea, a tray, a sponge or old brush, and a hairdryer on low.
- ◯ **From your adornments.** Leftover beads, thread, lace and ribbon.
- ◯ **From outside.** Leaves, pressed for a week in a heavy book.
- ◯ **The notebook.** One notebook and one smooth pen, kept where you wake.

Borrow the real thing.

Your library card opens newspapers you'd otherwise pay for. Go for the full-page PDF images, because they look like newspaper. Test-print one page before you commit.

Do	*Don't*
Page images	Text-only archive
Library card	Printing in a rush
One test print	Letting codes lapse

You need: a Hartford Public Library card to use these from home.

Hartford Courant, 2008 to about two weeks ago. Full-page PDF images with photos, ads and obituaries. The best for the newspaper look. New issues take about two weeks to appear.

Hartford Courant, 1764 to 1998. Full-page PDF images too, for older, vintage pages.

Hartford Courant, 1992 to today. Text only, with no photos or ads. Skip it for scrapbooking.

New York Times. The full site and app with your card. Access codes last 24 hours, so redeem a new one when you need it.

Chicago Tribune, 1985 to now. Also available with your card.

Printing. I couldn't confirm whether each database lets you print or download, so look for a print or PDF button inside it. If there isn't one, ask the reference desk on 860-695-6300 or at reference@hplct.org. The library also has mobile printing; check the cost first.

Find them. Search "Hartford Courant Databases" on hplct.libguides.com, or go to hplct.org/library-services/nyt for the Times.

3.. Your paper at a glance

Stain it first, print it second.

Tea gives you the colour and the crinkle. Ink goes on only after the paper is completely dry. Test every step on a scrap before you use your good page.

Do	*Don't*
Strong tea	Wet paper near the printer
Gentle crumple	Staining after printing
Full drying	Hot ovens

Step 1. Brew. Steep three or four black tea bags in a cup of hot water until it's dark. Let it cool.

Step 2. Stain. Lay the paper on a tray. Dab the tea on with a sponge or old brush, darker at the edges.

Step 3. Age. Crumple it gently, flatten it, and stain again where you want more colour.

Step 4. Dry. Dry flat on a towel, or on low with a hairdryer, then press under a heavy book for a day. It must be completely dry before it goes anywhere near a printer.

Step 5. Print. Feed one sheet at a time, on draft mode, and test on a scrap first. Newsprint soaks up ink, so the print comes out soft and a little bleedy, which looks vintage. Let the ink dry before gluing.

Step 6. Feed it straight. On an inkjet printer, tape the top edge of the newsprint to a normal sheet so it feeds through straight. On a laser printer, don't use tape: the heat can melt it and damage the machine. Use a thicker paper instead.

If it jams. Stop, open the printer and ease the paper out gently. Don't pull hard.

4. Your vision page at a glance

Lay it out before you glue.

Ten minutes is plenty. Choose six scraps, arrange them, then glue. Finish with one line in your own handwriting.

Do	*Don't*
Thin over thick	Glue stick on beads
One texture	Closing wet pages
One handwritten line	Overthinking

Choose. Six scraps that make you feel something.

Arrange. Lay them on the page first. Biggest at the back, smaller on top.

Glue. Glue stick for paper. PVA for beads, thread, lace and leaves, held in place for a minute.

Add one texture. A bead, a bit of thread, a pressed leaf.

Write. One line across the bottom, by hand.

Dry. Leave the notebook open for an hour. Slide baking paper between pages before you close it.

Layout. Front of the notebook for your daily lines, the middle for your downloads, the back for vision pages.

5. Your weeks at a glance

One page, six weeks.

You're not building a masterpiece. You're building a habit you can hold in your hands. If you miss a week, carry on with the next one.

Do	*Don't*
Ten minutes	Catching up
Same notebook	Comparing
Tick the circle	Perfect pages

- ◯ **Voice.** The studio, HAIRŪNA, the sound of the work.
  Look for: Studio light, waveforms, a lyric line you love, the colour your sound would be.
- ◯ **Adornments.** Waist beads, rings, bracelets, necklaces.
  Look for: Bead colours, metal textures, a design you want to make, a real bead or bit of thread glued down.
- ◯ **Hair.** The locs, the care, the crown.
  Look for: Length, oils, how you want to feel when you wash it, one word for your hair.
- ◯ **Home and rest.** Soft light, a calm room, deep sleep.
  Look for: Lamps, linen, a quiet corner, the stillness of the house at 3 a.m.
- ◯ **Roots.** St. Vincent, Tortola, the water, the bush.
  Look for: Leaves, sea colours, a family name, a phrase in Vincy.
- ◯ **Joy.** What makes me laugh with my whole belly.
  Look for: A song that makes you dance, a face that makes you laugh, a food you love.

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I will always find my way back.

Downloads, written down while they're still waves.

Today's lines

I feel everything, and I can stay steady while I do.

I don't have to earn rest.

My voice is allowed to be soft, and it's allowed to be heard.

I tell the truth and I don't have to over-explain it.

I choose who gets access to me.

I do for myself what nobody did for me.

Sound is how I come home.

The morning, in brief

Floor. Feet flat, and one slow breath down into the feet.

Water. Cool water over the wrists.

Sound. One song, out loud.

One line. Written by hand, once.

From the notebook

The wave. Write the first words that landed. Three words counts.

Page day. Ten minutes, a glue stick, and one line across the bottom.

Things that work

Feet flat on the floor, or sitting on it

Cool water on my wrists, or washing dishes

Singing out loud

Music, then a pause

Wall push, towel grip, yelling into a blanket

Writing the wave back to the baseline

A cool cloth on my daughter's legs when she's hot

Wanted: one quiet hour. Found: the way back.

Printed at home, for one reader.